

a helicopter parent's excessive preoccupation is not just with the child's well-being, but spills over into all aspects of his or her life—school projects, choice of friends, extra-curricular activities, and even simple, harmless fun. Clinical psychologist Shelja Sen, who works for Children First, a mental health service, spent long hours with the boy above, and realised that he felt “cornered” by his parents. “He kept saying that he doesn’t need to go for all those tuitions, except for math, and that he only enjoyed football,” adds Sen. The parents needed counselling, as well, to understand what they were doing wrong. That, as Sen says, “Every child cannot be forced to excel in everything, and that a child needs unstructured play time.”

Kanchan Ray, 55, from Kolkata can't help himself. He can't stop doing “what's best” for his daughter, Devdutta, and wants “to protect her from life's harsh blows”. So he thinks nothing of keeping tabs on who the 17-year-old socialises with, or browsing through her school books. He drops her off and picks her up from her coaching classes, in order to keep an eye on her friends. The days he can't make it, he directs his driver to keep a watch and report back to him. “She is young, and I want to keep her safe from the big, bad world out there,” says Ray, an employee of Indian Oil. Now that his daughter has finished Class XII and is about to enter college, Ray is clear about one thing: “My wife and I don't want her to leave Kolkata for her bachelors.” His reasoning? “She won't be able to manage without us. She's a bit shy. And we do know what's best for her.”

While the Rays may think so, the experts don't necessarily agree. “Parents these days get into their children's lives in every possible way, leaving precious little space for them to learn to take charge of it on their own,” says Sanjay Chugh, a Delhi-based psychiatrist. Part of the reason is the parents' anxiety to ensure that their children are growing up in the best possible environment. “Also, they want to prepare them for the fierce career competition they're bound to face. Somewhere along the line, the parents' goals gets transferred on to the child,” he adds.

Tanvi and Sachin Shah of Mumbai seldom



SUVASHIS MULLICK

WHY IS SMOTHERING ON THE RISE?

A generational attitude shift. A key aspect is the acceptance—and expectation—that parents will be highly involved in their children's lives.

Today's parents opt for fewer children, wait longer to have them and are more affluent. They tend to micromanage children's lives and have trouble letting go.

An outward sign of economic anxiety. Parents want to prepare children for the fierce competition they are likely to face in an uncertain job market.

“Parents want to turn two-year-olds into dazzling achievers.”



AMITHA PRASATH,
Principal, Prayag
Montessori, Bangalore

“Parents discuss every little thing happening in school.”



DEVI KAR,
Principal, Modern
High School for
Girls, Kolkata